

THE MASTER KEY

(Continued from page 4.)

CHAPTER XXIII.

The Quest of the Hindu.

THAT night Wilkerson sought out Jean Darnell. She received him in a manner that told him distinctly that she was in a towering rage, though she was outwardly calm.

Wilkerson said no attention apparently to her glaring eyes nor to her restrained, "Well, once more your schemes have failed."

"Not failed," he said boldly. "I admit we nearly passed up what we were looking for. Do you remember that idol that was in the chest?"

Jean stopped her nervous pacing of the floor and fixed her great, tawny eyes on Wilkerson.

"Harry," she said huskily, "I am weary of this."

"Wait a moment," he pleaded. "When I went back to the launch I found that Dorr had been quizzing the men about that image."

"And I suppose he had got it?"

"No, he didn't. One of the sailors

had picked it up and taken it to a pawnshop and sold it."

She stamped her foot.

"Where is it? What has it to do with the plans?"

"I don't know where it is," he responded sullenly. "A Hindu rug peddler bought it."

"And Dorr bought it from him?"

"Not yet," he said, risking the statement. "Now all I have to do is find Mr. Peddler and get it back."

Mrs. Darnell flung herself into a chair and laughed hysterically.

"You mean to tell me Tom Gallon hid his plans in a heathen idol and that we overlooked them and that a rug peddler has them now?"

She leaned forward, clenching her soft hands on her knees.

"Do you know all you have made me go through, Harry? Kidnaping, theft, murder—yes, murder—at the end of it all, when we neither of us dare breathe for fear of the police finally getting us, you tell me that a tramp has got what we want? I'm done!"

Wilkerson had expected and feared this. He saw his wild efforts going for nothing. Without her assistance and her money he was helpless.

And profounder even than his hatred of Dorr and his desire for the hidden wealth was his agony at the thought of his failure to win this woman whom he loved.

Love is a noun which conveys to the ordinary mortal no definite meaning without an adjective. There is, indeed, an essence of love, a complete and all absorbing passion, before which even the gods bow and against which the world is powerless. Too often we must describe it as lawless.

Yet it also exists when it evokes the reverence of the most cynical. Wilkerson's love for Jean Darnell was the very essence of his being.

It had made a bravo of a coward and had welded a dozen strands of viciousness, weakness, wickedness and treachery into a strong character—strong only in its relation to the woman.

The past few weeks, with their wildness, risk, crime and continual plotting, had made the Harry Wilkerson who was a weakling and sport of circumstances into a personality who must be dealt with.

Jean Darnell realized something of this when he next spoke.

"All this has been disappointing," he said quietly, his eyes burning steadily on hers. "But the more disappointments I have to overcome the more worth while it will make you."

"Quite an old time knight," she said scornfully, but with an effort.

"I am going to get that idol," he went on. "I know just two things—

"I'm going to get that idol."

There are millions in gold hidden in the 'Master Key' mine, and the plans are concealed in that image."

"When will you have them?" she cried, trying to fight against the man's evil power.

"Tomorrow," he returned.

"Even if Dorr and Ruth?"

He nodded gravely. She read the message in his eyes and shuddered. Wilkerson laughed. He had won. He had conquered not only the woman in that moment, but himself.

He was ready to do murder deliberately, without a qualm. There had been born in him another physical thirst—the blood lust.

He left immediately without uncovering his plans. He knew that the final victory would not be won until he could fit Jean Darnell's soft and avaricious palms with glittering gold, bespoken of gold that ran over, that spilled in luxuriant streams over her clutched fingers; gold that rang under her feet, that mounted like an enveloping flood about her till her flesh was bathed in it.

That night he paced the floor of his room, dreaming of gold and of blood.

So the next morning when John Dorr fared forth on his quest for the rug peddler Harry Wilkerson was not far behind him, watching his every move, studying him, trying to read what was in his mind. And all with the great question before him:

Had John Dorr the idol?

While these two were seeking for the strange image of an unknown god there was a third who had found in it the goal of his life's toil.

When God conceals himself from us in times of stress and agony, when he has closed his brazen heavens and our prayers die in the empty air it is but man to build for ourselves a tangible God, one whom we can see and feel, into whose face we can look and before whose feet we can lay our offerings and our petitions.

In a far city in India men had died of famine. The earth had turned to iron under their plows and the heavens to brass above them.

They had implored a hundred gods for help and made offerings at a thousand shrines. There had been no response. The smoke of the burning ghats by the side of the shrunken river told the sorry tale of prayer unanswered.

And in their last misery men turned, as men will, to one who dreamed. Reality was death. Dreams held out the promise of life.

And this dreamer, as do all who follow a vision, made his dream into a god.

People listened to his tale of a deity who was merciful to listen and powerful to save. They fed on the dreamer's words and called him a prophet.

Yet still the earth refused food, and the river shrank within its bed. Then they went to the prophet and called on him to save them and to call his god to their aid.

Like many prophets, he found himself forced to materialize his dream in order that the common folk might see and believe, for he had taught them that unless they believed there was no salvation.

"How can we believe in a god whom we cannot see?" they cried.

"I believe, though I do not see nor feel," he told them. But they were not satisfied and menaced him with death.

So he took metals and fire and made an image of his god and made a shrine for it and set the image in the shrine, where all might see and worship.

And the people prayed to this new god and laid offerings at his feet and

can city he dreamed that his god appeared to him and spoke of death and destruction yet to follow, commanding him to start instantly for the east.

The next day, while Dorr was seeking for a Hindu selling rugs and Wilkerson was shadowing him the new possessor of the idol was hastening to San Francisco to take steamer for India and the city by the river.

The image was concealed with all reverence in his bundle of rugs, and he moved cautiously, because of the dream.

Strange destiny that centered old Tom Gallon's plans for his daughter's happiness, Dorr's dreams of love, Jean Darnell's lust for wealth and Harry Wilkerson's passion for a woman without a heart in the possession of a grotesque image made by a dreamer in faroff India centuries before when a city died and a river waned within its bed.

CHAPTER XXIII.

Sir Donald Faversham Volunteers.

IN his search for the Hindu, who had bought the idol containing the plans of the mother of the "Master Key" mine, John Dorr had recourse again to the pawnbroker.

That individual's curiosity was aroused by now, and he asked a great many questions, which John answered evasively.

When it came to getting a description of the Hindu the broker could give but few details.

He laid emphasis on the fact that he sold rugs and that he looked like any one of a dozen East Indians frequenting a Pacific port. He knew of no address.

With this Dorr had to content, and he returned to Ruth to discuss with her what they should do next.

"If Wilkerson gets it there is an easy way to get him," he said in the course of their conversation.

"How?" demanded Ruth.

"Have him arrested as a fugitive from justice and held for the county sheriff and the warrant that Tom Kane swore out," he replied.

Ruth considered this thoughtfully and shook her head.

"It would mean our going back to the mine and all kinds of trouble," she said wisely. "Besides, we wouldn't be any nearer the papers father wanted me to have."

"That is very true," John agreed.

"We'll keep that in reserve in case we discover that he has the idol. Our only plan, then, is to trace this Hindu. That will be a hard job."

"Why not put detectives on the trail?"

"I don't think any detective could do better than myself," was the reply.

"But you can't do it all," she argued. "You can't be looking for this peddler and keeping an eye on Wilkerson and seeing to me at the same time."

"The seeing to you is the pleasantest part of the job," he said laughingly. "I refuse to delegate that to any one. Of course you're quite right, though, about it's being too big an affair for me to handle alone. I think I'll ask Everett to join us. I'll write him, and then we'll take a trip down to the water front and interview our lunchman."

FORUM OF THE PEOPLE

Pheasants in Wheat Fields.

Farmer wanted to know what to do when pheasants get into wheat fields and injure crops. What can be done?

FARMER.

(Write to W. L. Finley, state game warden, Yeon Bldg., Portland, Oregon, and he has statutory authority to afford you adequate remedy.—Editor.)

Cuts, Burns, Bruises, Sores, Wounds and Fles quickly healed with Arnica Salve. It prevents infection, is antiseptic, soothing, healing. Try it once. Money Back If It Fails. The Original and Genuine.

Bucklen's Arnica Salve Heals the Hurt All Druggists and Dealers, 25c.

who had stolen it dead in a lane with a knife between his shoulders. And his murderer, who discovered in a Chinese quarter, crying horribly at the sky, with a rope twisted tightly about his neck.

So the image passed from hand to hand, always bringing with it death, until some sailor hid it in his chest, and when he had been washed overboard in a storm and his effects were distributed a captain bought the idol for a curio.

It was in his chest that Thomas Gallon had found it when seeking a safe place to hide his precious papers in time of mutiny and fire.

Now, at last, it had fallen into the hands of one of the seekers, and he took it to his little tenement room and prayed to it and swore that he would return it to its proper place in the temple.

There was no response from the image, but when the Indian fell asleep on his rug that night in the alien American.

Seeing to you is the pleasantest part of the job."

a temple. What more natural than that he should see the chance of a great reward for doing a pious duty and returning it to its native place?"

"But that's all guesswork," Ruth insisted practically.

"I know it," he admitted. "But a good guess is better than nothing to work on. Let's go and see our skipper person."

The launch captain received them generally and listened to John's story at its finish he agreed with John that it was very likely that the Indian had recognized a native god and would restore it to its own temple.

"I've visited those eastern ports a good deal," he told them. "I know boys on a lark from the ship will do just that trick—rip off with an idol for a curio—and I know the fuss the brethren make about it too. They'll go any length to get back a first chop god."

Before they left he promised to keep an eye open for the Hindu and inform them if he got the smallest clew. With this they had to be satisfied, as inquiries elsewhere developed nothing helpful.

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FEEL BLUE—OR JUST STUPID?

Sluggish bowels and torpid liver usually go together and it does not take long for constipation to produce a bad condition—a feeling of languor or lassitude—the "blues," headaches, palpitation or other malady. Indeed, when in this condition the system invites more serious illness and is not able to throw off disease. Foley Cathartic Tablets are a wholesome laxative and cleansing cathartic. They act without inconvenience, griping or sickening. Jones Drug Co.

"I see your point," the promoter said promptly. "My offer of days ago still holds good. I'll finance this matter to the end, and I'll look after the mine too. So you can be care free so far as that goes, John."

"You know I wouldn't take it for myself," John began awkwardly and was silenced by a smile.

The next morning they and barely finished breakfast when the launch captain was announced.

The three of them found him bursting with news.

"I think I wanted your Hindu," he told them. "He came down at day-light this morning looking for a steam

engine. He seemed to me a pretty level headed chap, and he'll maybe be able to put us on the track of the Hindu if he took a steamer for the north, as I strongly suspect he did."

Ruth could not understand why the peddler should do this, and Dorr explained that the Hindu evidently had set great store on the idol as he had not only paid cash, but had given a rug as well in exchange.

"He would know that the thing was worthless as an article of merchandise," he went on. "In the next place, he wasted no time in getting possession of it once he saw it. I have no doubt that it is sacred in his eyes—no god. It was stolen at some time from

of sailing for the north. The Hindu leaves at noon, and the steward gave him a job to the guile."

"But it might be another Hindu," Ruth suggested.

The captain turned toward her and shook his head. "I don't think it's possible," he said. "He answered the description clear down to the rug. Besides that, he seemed kind of nervous, and when one of the sailors jolled him the man nearly had a fit. I'm sure he's your man."

"There's only one thing for you to do," Everett said promptly—"take passage on that steamer yourselves to San Francisco. By that time you can be pretty sure whether he's your man or not."

This was agreed upon, and Ruth started on her preparations immediately, Everett insisting that she take her maid with her.

"But I don't need her!" Ruth protested. "She's so expensive too!"

"You are merely a youngster," Everett said quietly, "and you must have a woman traveling with you. It is all right to do as you like in the mines, where no one would dream of speaking evil or thinking it, but Mrs. Grundy insists on the maid."

John agreed with Everett and departed to get the tickets, in spite of Everett's warning that he had better send and get them.

The result was that George Drake, just landed from the mine and in search of Wilkerson, found him shad owing Dorr.

Drake explained his coming by saying that he had heard nothing from either Wilkerson or Mrs. Darnell, and he could be of no use at the "Master Key."

"It's just as well," Wilkerson said sulkily. "I have a dozen things to attend to, and you can help. The first is not to let that man Dorr get out of our sight or turn a hand unless we know it."

In a few sentences, filled with bitterness he told the story of the finding of the chest and the futile search for the plans and the abstraction of the idol containing them.

When Wilkerson found that Dorr and Ruth booked passage on the Halcyon for San Francisco and had inquired about the next sailings for the Orient he took Drake aside and they determined that this could only mean one thing—

Dorr was on the track of the idol.

"We'll follow them," he said sardonically. "We've spent too much to quit now."

Jean Darnell received Drake coolly and listened to Wilkerson's explanation of his new scheme without a word.

Her stormy eyes boded no good to some one, and Wilkerson feared she would abandon him.

But there was the tenacity of a tiger in her passions, and now she could not give up her sweet revenge nor forego the thought of possessing the wealth which had once been Tom Gallon's and which he had tried to conceal.

She agreed to go, and they decided to leave by train that evening, this being in San Francisco in time to meet the steamer and watch for Dorr's next movement.

Two days later Everett again met John and Ruth in the hotel in San Francisco.

John's news was that the Hindu they sought had undoubtedly been on the Halcyon and that John had bought a steamer passage for Bombay.

"You ought to get the plans before you get to India," Everett said earnestly. "You'll find yourself in a strange land, where it will be like looking for a needle in a haystack to get hold of your man."

Dorr acknowledged this and outlined his tentative plan of getting hold of the idol during the passage.

"After all, we don't want the idol I shall try to persuade the man of this and get him to let me have the papers concealed in it."

At this moment Sir Donald Faversham was announced.

The entrance of the Englishman who had made himself so attentive to Ruth at the southern hotel awakened little enthusiasm in either Dorr or Everett, but for Ruth's sake they played the civil part.

She, on the other hand, received Sir Donald with every evidence of lively pleasure.

"We are this minute talking of going over to India, where you lived so long," she told him after the first greetings. "And you are just the man to tell us all about it."

"Going to India?" ejaculated the baronet. "My word!"

"Yes," she proceeded. "We are after a Hindu and his idol."

At this point John laughingly came to the rescue and briefly explained the object of their quest.

Sir Donald listened quietly, occasionally glancing at Ruth, whose beauty was enhanced by pretty excitement.

At the conclusion of the tale he nursed the end of his stick awhile in very apparent perplexity.

"You know, my dear fellow," he said, addressing John, "that India is a large country filled with millions of different races. Even granting that this man is a Hindu and that your surmise about the idol is correct, I don't see how you are going to accomplish anything."

"That is just where you can help us," said Ruth impulsively.

For the instant Sir Donald actually blushed with embarrassment.

Then he gathered himself together and went into details of what they must expect and the difficulties they must encounter.

"If you could only go alone!" Ruth said plaintively when he had got them thoroughly discouraged. "You could talk their horrid language and make them behave."

"By Jove," said the baronet, smiling, "that's not a half bad idea! I have nothing to do, and I might as well see the chaps in India again as stay here."

"You know, Sir Donald was in the army there," Ruth explained to Everett.

"Brought up there," Faversham added. "Know India pretty well. I really believe I'll go with you if you'll accept of my company. Want a lark?"

Neither John nor Everett received this proposal with undue warmth, but Ruth found it delightful, and before any of them realized the seriousness of the conversation everything had

been arranged.

Outside Faversham spoke to Dorr as man to man.

"I don't want to thrust myself on you in any way," he said briefly. "I happen to know India and to be sure that I can be of service to you. In fact, I should think it a jolly trip. But if you think I took advantage of the little lady's courtesy say so."

Entirely disarmed, John Dorr had to confess that Sir Donald's offer relieved him of a responsibility too heavy for him.

The two parted the best of friends, though John could not refrain from an expression of jealousy to himself.

But he knew that Ruth's interests were now doubly safeguarded and tried to restrain his uneasy heart.

As the steamer sailed the next day they had little time for their preparations, but John made sure that the Hindu was on board before the last line was cast off and the big liner backed into the stream and headed slowly round for the channel to the open sea.

(To be continued.)

BILLY SUNDAY, REVIVALIST.

Former Player Is Holding Successful Meetings in Philadelphia.

Billy Sunday, once a baseball player, is now a revivalist, which partially answers the question as to what becomes of old players. For some weeks he has been conducting services in Philadelphia and has been unusually successful. He is planning an assault on New York if the proper arrangements can be made.

Sunday recently took sides in the baseball war and advised players to stick to organized ball. He declared his belief that the Federal league was likely to be harmful to players, and he does not think that the demoralization the new league has caused can have other than a harmful effect on the game.

When he was a player Sunday was regarded as a plous sort of chap, and his presence had a softening effect on the other players. He did not lecture them, but it was known that he did not like bad language, and as a rule his teammates were careful of their words when he was around.

Callahan Never Signed Contract.

James J. Callahan, former manager of the White Sox, occupies a position in baseball that is unique. He is the only man connected with the playing end of the game who does not sign a contract. He managed the Sox for three years and during that time never affixed his signature to a piece of paper.

Beaverton: Fisher block to be built will cost \$9000.

5 Women Avoid Operations

For years we have been stating in the newspapers of the country that a great many women have escaped serious operations by taking Lydia E. Pinkham's Vegetable Compound, and it is true.